



Elite company: Pratika finished fourth on the 2025 ODI World Cup run charts with 308, behind Laura Wolvaardt, Smriti Mandhana and Ashleigh Gardner. EMMANUAL YOGINI

because they didn't like who I am. Every insecurity for a 14-year-old came bubbling up. My parents quickly addressed that, saying it's all about perspective. The world has a lot to offer. One just has to ask. I live by those words.

"Now you're going to say, *'Isme bhi positive dekh rahi hai'* (laughs), but I am glad that happened early in my life. I don't ever have to go through that again. Everything happens for a reason."

Pratika has never been one to shy away from hard work and had her father, Pradeep, to fuel that fire.

In nets set up on their terrace, the duo trained endlessly during the

pandemic, hitting close to 500 balls a day. The pair had their fun too. "We used to bowl to each other from the beginning. We had bets to see if he could dismiss me or vice versa. He used to get me out a lot, but times have thankfully changed," she quips.

Her ambitions took flight when Indian women's cricket sprouted wings of its own. The 2017 World Cup doubled her family's belief in their daughter having a future in a sport she was already so good at. Seven years later, when she broke into the dressing room, standing shoulder to shoulder with names she grew up idolising, Pratika, in her zeal to do things the right way, didn't know the correct protocol.

"I thought you had to behave a certain way here. You had to say good morning to everyone whenever you saw them. Turns out it was all in my head. I could be myself. If I didn't want to talk that day, it was

fine. There were no obligations to do anything. It was such a comforting environment."

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As her numbers suggest, she thrived. There was the shadow of Shafali Verma's flamboyance hanging around that position, but Pratika was clear about doing things her way, something the dugout and her partner, Smriti, encouraged.

"When I play, I don't think about anything else. It's just me, the ball, the bowler, and the fielders I have to pierce. My parents always told me that my only focus should be the game; everything else is a distraction. I don't have things running at the back of my mind. If anything, there are a lot of goals there that constantly swirl around, things I need to get done."

An academic curiosity about psychology helped that